ENGL 46700/56701 · Writing for Multiple Media, Interaction Design

Prototypes & Interaction Diagrams

What they are, what they're not, and how to build yours

What IS a Clickable Prototype?

✓ What it IS

- Linked frames someone else can click through
- Simulates the experience of using your system
- Shows: user action → system response
- Can be built in Google Slides, PowerPoint, or Figma
- Does NOT need to cover every screen
- Does NOT need visual polish

✗ What it is NOT

- A flowchart or diagram (those go in Section 2)
- A wireframe sketch showing how screens relate
- A presentation you advance slide by slide
- Something that requires you to explain it
- Code

The Key Test

Can someone who has never seen your project
open it, click a button, and end up somewhere?

YES →
You have a prototype.

NO →
You have a presentation.
Add hyperlinks.

Building Your Prototype in Google Slides

1

Design your screens

Each slide = one screen. Don't worry about visual polish. Label the key elements — buttons, menus, prompts.

2

Add hyperlinks

Select a button shape or text. Go to Insert → Link → Slides in this presentation. Choose the slide it leads to.

3

Test in Present mode

Open Slideshow view and click through as a user would. If you get stuck, you're missing a link.

4

Focus on one path

Cover the most important interaction for one persona. 4–6 linked screens is enough. Depth over breadth.

A Note for Figma Users

⚠️ **AI-generated Figma prototypes often look complete but have no live connections.**

Open your file right now and click through it in Presentation mode. If clicking a button does nothing — you need to add connections manually.

How to add connections in Figma:

- Select the button or element you want to make clickable
- In the right panel, click the Prototype tab (next to Design and Inspect)
- Click "+ Add interaction" and choose the destination frame
- Use the Play button (top right) to test in Presentation mode

Part 2

Interaction Diagrams

What they show, what they must include, and how they connect to your prototype

What Your Diagram Must Show

User Actions

What does the user do at each step? Click, select, type, speak, swipe. Be specific.

System Responses

What does the system do back? Display a screen, confirm an action, show an error, offer a choice. The system is an actor too.

Decision Points

Anywhere the user has more than one path. Accept or dismiss? Stay or exit? Choose A or B? These are diamonds in your flow.

Friction / Breakdown

At least one moment where the original system failed. Label it clearly. This is the reason your redesign exists.

Diagram vs. Prototype: Two Views of the Same Thing

Section 2 · Interaction Diagram

A map of the interaction logic.

- Shows the full structure of decisions and responses
- Includes error states and alternate paths
- Covers both personas if needed
- Static — someone reads it, they don't click it
- Can be hand-drawn, Figma, Canva, or PowerPoint shapes

→

same interaction

Section 3 · Clickable Prototype

A simulation of the experience.

- Focuses on one persona's most important interaction
- 4–6 linked screens is enough
- Someone clicks through it without you explaining
- Interactive — buttons go somewhere
- Google Slides, PowerPoint, or Figma with live links

Before You Submit: Checklist

Prototype	Open your prototype and click through it in presentation mode. Does it work without you explaining it?
Diagram	Does your diagram show user actions, system responses, at least one decision point, and at least one friction/breakdown?
Connection	Does your diagram and prototype cover the same interaction — just from different angles?
Scope	Have you focused on the most important interaction for at least one persona? You don't need to cover everything.
Gaps	Do you have any placeholder sections or missing pieces? Fill them before peer review.